Once Upon a Tim

By Stuart Gibbs

Suggested Roles: ***Actor:*** *Tim, Nerlim, Stinx*
Actress: *Belinda, Princess Grace, Town Crier, Ruprecht,*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

TIM: **(Pg 1-7)** Once upon a time there was a prince who was revered throughout the land for being exceptionally brave in the face of grave danger *(strike a brave pose)*

BELINDA: This is NOT his story.

TIM: *(drops façade)* Well, there are lots of other people who aren't princes or princesses and trust me: we have way more problems than the rich folks do.

BELINDA: We're called peasants. And being a peasant stinks. We're all really, really poor.

TIM: See [what] I'm wearing? The only clothes I own. I've been wearing the same outfit for two years – and it was a hand-me-down from a cousin who wore it for two years before me.

BELINDA: All the princes and princesses live in castles with hundreds of rooms.

TIM: I live in a hut *(gestures to imaginary dwelling)* You might be thinking to yourself, "Gosh, that's awfully small, but it looks cozy." Well, it's not! Peasants can't afford fancy stuff. Any animal that wants to get into your house can do it!

BELINDA: Flies *(swats at a fly)*, lice *(scratches furiously)*, raccoons . . .

TIM: . . . wild boars and the occasional dragon *(scans the sky)*. Here are a few other things we don't have: Air-conditioning, refrigerators, televisions

BELINDA: Internet. Bathrooms!

TIM: We don't have bathrooms. No toilets! I'll admit the princes and princesses don't have flush toilets either, but they at least have professional wipers to clean them afterward.

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BELINDA: Like I said, being a peasant stinks! *(sniffs Tim and makes a face)*

TIM: There is one way a peasant can change his lot in life. It's ridiculously, terribly, insanely dangerous. But if you're smart, brave, confident –

BELINDA: And if you don't die in the process . . .

TIM: This is the story of how I took that shot.

INTRODUCTION

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TIM: **(Pg 9-13)** My story begins with a princess . . . Princess Grace, who lives in the next kingdom. *(gazes at her adoringly until she begins to sing)*

PRINCESS: *(singing – off key and badly and continues during Tim's next line)*

TIM: *(making a face in response to her singing, covers ears)* People ***said*** she had a voice like an angel, and that when she sang woodland creatures would gather around and gaze at her adoringly. *(shakes head)* You can't believe ***everything*** you hear.

PRINCESS: AIEEEEE!! *(she is snatched away by a monster)*

TIM: Princess Grace was snatched away by a ***stinx***. Not a sphinx. A ***stinx!***

BELINDA: It has the left side of a lion, the wings of a bat . . .

TIM: . . . and the right side of an entirely different lion who doesn't get along with the first.

BELINDA: It's always in an incredibly bad mood and has a smell –

TIM: A malodorous stench – that keeps anyone from coming within 5 miles of it.

BELINDA: **(Pg 15-17)** Prince Ruprecht had a serious crush on Princess Grace. He decided to defeat the stinx, rescue the princess and win her hand in marriage -- along with all of her money.

TIM: There were just two problems: 1) Ruprecht was a coward

BELINDA: And 2) He didn't have any knights to join him on his quest. His sinister adviser, Nerlim, came up with a dastardly plan. It required someone they could take advantage of. Basically, it required a sucker.

TIM: That's where I come in! *(both begin chopping wood)* **(Pg 21)** I was chopping wood with

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Belinda when we heard the news. Belinda was not supposed to be chopping wood at all, because she was a girl. **(Pg 23)** [And] while I was annoyed by my lack of options in life, Belinda's options were even worse: making dinner, scrubbing floors, taking care of children and if they were princesses . .

BELINDA: Getting abducted by mythical creatures! *(laughs)*

TIM: If a girl wasn't born royal, she had two career choices: housewife or witch. *(Belinda cackles)* We were in the woods near the castle when the town crier came along.

TOWN CRIER: **(Pg 25)** *(unrolls a scroll and begins reaching; actually sobbing)* Princess . . . WAAAHHHH . . . Grace . . . AAAUUGGHH . . . has been . . . BOOHOOHOO . . . taken!

TIM: **(Pg 26)** *(grabs the scroll and reads aloud)* Kidnapped by a stinx . . . looking for brave men to become knights and join me to rescue Prince Grace . . . Have a nice day – Prince Ruprecht

BELINDA: *(gasps with excitement)* Help convince Prince Ruprecht that I'm a boy! I'll tuck my ponytail under my hat, steal some boy's clothes and act dumber than usual. *(spits and scratches her butt)*

TIM: **(Pg 34)** *(considering)* Belinda ***was*** smarter and braver than anyone I knew. I couldn't imagine anyone better to have by my side. *(to Belinda)* I'll do it!

BELINDA: **(Pg 43)** *(to audience)* We were going on a quest!

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TIM: **(Pg 58)** The whole town came to see us off and cheered for Ruprecht as he bravely let the way. *(Ruprecht smiles regally and waves to the crowd)* **(Pg 60-61)** However, once we were aways from the town . . .

RUPRECHT: *(dropping his façade and whining)* How much farther is it? This is boooooring. *(to Nerlim)* Can't you just do some magic and get us there instantly?

NERLIM: Um . . . no. . . [but] I have a map! *(unfurls another scroll)*

BELINDA: We had always been told Nerlim was a great and powerful wizard, but the person who told us that was Nerlim himself. He was always proclaiming things like:

NERLIM: Behold! I am Nerlim, the great and powerful wizard! Do not cross me, or I shall turn

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you into a newt!

BELINDA: *(looks to left, the right, then whispers)* I had never seen him turn anyone into a newt.

NERLIM: BEHOLD! *(makes a grand gesture)*

BELINDA: **(Pg 73)** We're wasting time. Are we going to rescue the princess or not? *(to audience)*

TIM: *(making small talk as they walk)* I was hoping we'd have a break before encountering something doom-y. Like maybe the Fields of Joy or the Path of Pleasantness. . . [but] we headed into the Forest of Doom. *(intimidating sound effect)*

BELINDA: **(Pg 79-80)** This river doesn't look so bad. And look – there's even a raft!

NERLIM: Wait! This is called the River of Doom. Why would it be called the River of Doom if there wasn't any doom?

RUPRECHT: Maybe it was a marketing thing? My uncle, King Snodgrass discovered a beautiful place to build a kingdom, but he didn't want anyone invading him, so he named it Plague City and now everyone avoids it like the plague.

NERLIM: I heard that place was a cesspit!

RUPRECHT: Exactly! It's all marketing! This river looks fabulous *(sing the last word)*!

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TIM: **(Pg 121-122)** The stinx's lair wasn't hard to find. All we had to do was follow the smell, which could only be described as: HOLY COW THIS IS THE MOST HORRIBLE, DISGUSTING, AWFUL STENCH I HAVE EVER ENCOUNTERED ON EARTH!

BELINDA: *(looking incredulously at Tim – then speaks to the audience, holding her nose)* Luck appeared to be on our side. The stinx wasn't at home,

TIM: But we could see the distant form of Princess Grace far across the cave.

RUPRECHT: **(Pg 124-126)** *(also holding his nose)* Beer not, bear baidin! I'll save you! *(rushes cross-stage)*

TIM: He dashed across the cave, swept the princess up in his arms and then . . . her head fell off! *(all scream and cover their eyes- Tim peeks then approaches)* [We] steeled ourselves for the sight of some disgusting carnage but . . . *(picks up the body)* It's a doll!

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PRINCESS GRACE: *(stepping from the shadows)* Hi there! *(all scream)* I didn't mean to scare you. The stinx didn't actually want to steal ***me***. It only wanted a dress for its doll. I just happened to be wearing the one it liked best.

TIM: [We] had plenty of follow-up questions, but before we could ask them, a shadow fell over all of us.

BELINDA: Our luck seemed to have run out.

TIM: The stinx was home! **(Pg 127-129)** [We] turned around slowly, expecting to find ourselves face-to-face with he most vicious, terrifying, ill-tempered beast . . .

STINX: *(poses with large doe eyes, flaps its wings gently and makes a purring sound)*

BELINDA: Awwwww! It's a baby!

NERLIM: And it's adorable!

STINX: *(flaps over to the doll, picks it up notices the head is missing and starts to cry)*

PRINCESS GRACE: Don't worry, Fluffy! It was just an accident.

TIM: **(Pg 130-133)** So you weren't being held prisoner her? You could have left at any time? Why didn't you?

PRINCESS GRACE: *(pauses to think)* Well, when a princess gets into trouble, she's not supposed to rescue herself. She's supposed to wait for a brave and handsome prince to rescue her – and once he does, they look into each other's eyes and fall madly in love – and possibly sing a delightful song about it.

TIM: You ***could*** have rescued yourself at any time . . .

BELINDA: *(righteous indignation)* Society has taught you that you had to wait for a man to come and save you? You have to be kidding me! This whole idea that you shouldn't be able to rescue yourself because you're a woman is garbage.

TIM: Women can do anything that men can**.**

RUPRECHT: *(asserting his dominance)* I am the Brave Prince Ruprecht and I have saved you from the vile stinx! You are only a woman, while I am a man! It is only right for you to fall madly in love with me! *(laughing mockingly)*

PRINCESS GRACE: *(angrily)* But you didn't save me . . . *(whacks him with Fluffy's doll; Ruprecht*

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is knocked out cold – to others) **(Pg 141)** There's no way I'm marrying that guy. He's a jerk! *(spits and scratches her butt)*

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TIM: So that's how I became a knight and how Belinda became one too. But [we] learned some things.

BELINDA: Princes aren't always brave and honorable

TIM: Some beasts aren't nearly as vicious and mean as people say they are.

BELINDA: Princesses don't always need a hero to rescue them. And if they do, they're under no legal obligation to fall in love! *(spits and scratches butt)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Stuart Gibbs
ISBN: 978-1534499256
Publisher: Simon and Schuster Books
Date (Month/Year): Mar 2022

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier – MS

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